

Sardine x [Mal.ai](#)

Fast-tracking global stablecoin infrastructure

Overview

[Mal.ai](#) is building a global financial account for the world's unbanked earners, including freelancers receiving USD income outside the US banking system, students funded from abroad, and patients sponsored by Gulf governments. The infrastructure challenge is real: connecting these users to US payment rails, issuing USD accounts and crypto wallets, running compliant KYC and AML across high-complexity geographies, and doing it fast.

Sardine has already built this. We ran a global USD/USDC account product in partnership with fintechs and sponsor banks, operating across similar corridors to what [Mal.ai](#) is targeting. We know where the friction lives, which bank partners have the appetite, and what a compliant, scalable architecture looks like. **We are ready to reactivate this infrastructure with Mal.ai as the anchor client.**

What Sardine Brings

E2E Risk & Compliance Stack

- **KYC / IDV:** Hosted onboarding widget or API-based ingestion. Document verification, liveness, eKYC, sanctions and PEP screening in a single flow. Deployable in days, not months.
- **Source of Funds Verification:** Purpose-built for the freelancer persona. Income verification against Upwork history, contract data, and platform payment records. This is the framework that unlocks underwriting and EWA for users with no traditional credit profile.
- **AML Transaction Monitoring:** Real-time and batch TM tuned to inbound payroll and peer-to-peer remittance patterns. Rules-based and AI-augmented. Configurable by corridor and risk tier.
- **Sanctions and Adverse Media Screening:** OFAC, UN, EU, local lists. Ongoing monitoring, not just point-in-time at onboarding.
- **Issuing Fraud and Card Risk Scoring:** For virtual card programs issued on top of the USD account. Sardine scores every transaction in real time. No separate integration required.
- **Case Management and SAR/UAR Filing:** Full compliance operations tooling. Investigations, escalation workflows, and regulatory reporting built in.

This is a single vendor covering what typically requires three or four point solutions. For a team moving at [Mal.ai](#)'s pace, consolidation matters.

US Payment Rails and Account Infrastructure

How This Accelerates [Mal.ai](#)'s GTM

Freelancer Corridor (Phase 1)

- **Large, proven wedge:** MENA and Asian freelancers (4M+ earners, ~\$700M remittance) are already paying 5–10% FX via Swift/Payoneer.
- **Simple user flow:** Upwork client pays into a US ACH account. Funds arrive in USD.
- **Better economics:** Users can hold USD, convert to USDC, or send home via stablecoin rails at ~1–2% all-in.
- **Compliance + bank comfort:** Sardine runs KYC at onboarding, AML monitoring, and real-time card risk scoring, giving the sponsor bank a compliant program with a proven operator.
- **Fast launch:** Existing configuration for this persona is a working template, not a starting point. [Mal.ai](#) does not rebuild what we already know.

Student and Medical Corridors (Phase 2)

- **Lower risk:** Identifiable, documentable users with institutional funding sources.
- **Same stack:** KYC on student or patient, wallet issuance, inbound USDC, outbound USD payment via ACH or Wire.
- **Ready now:** Sardine can process these off-ramp transactions today.
- **Large volume:** ~\$8B Gulf-to-US tuition + ~\$18B UAE international patient spend, mostly moving via Swift at 2–4% fees.

FAQ

1. **Does Sardine hold AML program liability for [Mal.ai](#)'s users?**
No. [Mal.ai](#) is the regulated entity. Sardine provides the technology, tooling, and compliance infrastructure. The AML program ownership sits with [Mal.ai](#) and its sponsor bank. This is the same structure used by our existing clients.
2. **Does [Mal.ai](#) need to establish its own US bank relationship?**
Not to launch. Sardine facilitates introductions to sponsor bank partners with established programs for this use case. As the program scales, [Mal.ai](#) can elect to hold a direct relationship.
3. **What does integration look like?**
Sardine's KYC widget is embeddable via a hosted URL or API. AML monitoring is API-first. Most clients reach production-ready status within 4–8 weeks for the compliance stack. Payment infrastructure timelines depend on sponsor bank onboarding, typically 4–6 weeks in parallel.
4. **What geographies are supported at launch?**
Sardine's KYC coverage includes Pakistan, Egypt, India, UAE, and 50+ additional countries. AML rules are configurable by corridor. Geographic expansion does not require a new integration.
5. **What happened to Sardine's prior Global Payouts product?**
The product operated successfully with multiple fintech partners before being sunset in 2023 due to the US regulatory environment at the time. That environment has materially changed. The core infrastructure, bank relationships, and operational know-how are intact.

Next Step

We propose a focused working session with the [Mal.ai](#) team that covers:

- Bank partner selection
- KYC architecture
- Contract structure
- Realistic launch scope

The goal of this session is to decide how we will assemble the pieces Sardine already has in place for Mal's specific product and market sequence.